A Grant Proposal Seeking Funding for the Creation of an After-School Literacy Program and Library Investment in Elementary Schools

December 15, 2025

Submitted by Jenna Marino

On Behalf of the Children's Literacy Project

60 E S Temple St #110

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Dear Mrs. McCarthey,

I am delighted to submit this grant proposal to the McCarthey Dressman Education Foundation on behalf of the Children's Literacy Project (CLP). CLP is a nonprofit organization dedicated to advancing children's literacy in initiatives across the nation. They have equipped schools, churches, and community groups by fueling literacy projects such as the one proposed in this application. The main objective of this proposed initiative is to create an after-school program that recuperates the reading and writing skills of children who have fallen below grade level as well as equip school libraries with updated books, technology, and resources. This program is not only beneficial to the children who will regain the skill level the need to maintain proficient literacy, but also the school. Libraries that are underfunded would receive the help they need to promote and maintain a high literacy rate among students.

I want to implement this program in Long Island New York, specifically Lafrancis Hardiman Elementary School in the Wyandanch Union Free school district. In recent years, this school has been identified as underperforming in test achievement and in need of funding support. By testing this program in a school that is currently underperforming, I will be able to determine if the program is sufficient in improving academic performance. If it is successful, this program could be expanded to other underperforming districts within Suffolk County.

If this program is to be successful in elevating academic performance via improved literacy rates, it must be funded by an accredited foundation that respects power of language in the development of children, and how a foundation in literacy is fundamental to academic and professional success. On behalf of the Children's Literacy Project, this proposal seeks a total of $20,000 over the course of two years to create an after-school program in the Riverhead school district that supports children below reading level in order to improve academic performance and ensure a strong foundation in literacy. We are extremely grateful for your consideration and look forward to further collaboration in this endeavor.

Sincerely,

Jenna Marino

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1. Statement of Problem

The lack of literacy is an issue plaguing thousands of students across the United States. Students who lack comprehensive reading, writing, and critical thinking skills are often left behind by their classmates, never given the chance to catch up on skills they have missed. Many children enter kindergarten without the pre-reading skills they need to succeed, setting them up for failure right from the start.

The literacy crisis can be defined by a phenomenon known as "functional illiteracy." The National Library of Medicine defines functional illiteracy as, "a person [who] cannot use reading, writing, and calculation skills for his/her own and the community's development." Many students struggling with reading skills remain undetected by their educators by cheating their way through assignments involving reading comprehension and writing. They become embarrassed and unwilling to admit that they cannot read at the skill level of their peers. This creates a cycle of an aversion to literature due to skill insecurity, and continuing to have skill insecurity due to their aversion to literature. They are susceptible to low self-esteem, poor academic performance, and in the future, may have difficulty finding employment. In essence, functional illiteracy is a real and present danger to current schoolchildren and to the society they will enter.

Lexia finds that, "ninety percent of all students who struggle with reading in first grade will continue to struggle". This alarming statistic debunks the myth of the "late bloomer." Parents and educators who believe children will come to reading at their own pace are allowing students who do not have reading and writing skills to fall further and further behind. The literacy crisis in America has been increasing steadily over the last decade. Some theorize it is due to COVID; however, data shows that literacy rates have been declining well before the pandemic. NAEP

scores from 2019 show that compared to 2017, the reading scores of fourth graders were lower.[1]

The most likely culprit is the inability of the public school system to detect and support children who are consistently testing below grade level. The public schools that are unable to provide students with additional support are often low-income districts. Minority students are also at a higher risk of literacy deficits. Norma Nelson runs an organization dedicating to boosting literacy in children in Texas. Nelson states that across the nation, "only 18 percent of black students and 21 percent of Hispanic students test 'above proficient' in reading by the end of fourth grade."[2]

Literacy is essential for academic success, but it is also essential for children to develop into functioning members of society. Low literacy rates in high schools are associated with "long-term health issues, including aggressive behaviors, substance abuse, and sexually transmitted infections".[3] Students who do not know how to read and comprehend information effectively are at a massive disadvantage later in life. They cannot make informed decisions for themselves, their health, or their careers. In New York State, approximately 3.9 million New York state residents are functionally illiterate and read below a 5th grade level. 43% of adults with the lowest literacy skills are currently impoverished.[4] These people began their academic careers at a severe disadvantage. Failure to develop reading skills prevents children from being able to access higher information and knowledge. For high school students to enter college or the workforce with the skills they need, literacy must be established and enforced from the moment they enter the public school system.

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[1] *The Condition of Education 2020 | 1*, nces.ed.gov/programs/coe/pdf/coe_cnb.pdf.
[2] "10 Costs and Consequences of the Literacy Crisis." *Lexia*, www.lexialearning.com/blog/10-costs-and-consequences-literacy-crisis. Accessed 15 Dec. 2025.
[3] Steckel, Eric. "Reading for Life: The Impact of Child Literacy on Health Outcomes." *Children Rising*, 10 Aug. 2023
[4] PSG, 360. "About Literacy NY." *Literacy New York*, www.literacynewyork.org/about-us.

Furthermore, the role of a school library is invaluable to the learning capability of the students. Salma Bakash, a high school student in New York, recognizes the value of her school library as a necessary third space. "Libraries are places of community-building and socialization – essential at a time when many teens are struggling with isolation and mental health challenges… Our librarians encouraged connection by hosting book clubs, "talking circles" about current events, and oversized board game days."[5] Libraries are essential safe spaces for children not only struggling with literacy, but also with personal issues. Spaces where students feel welcomed and accepted are essential in improving attendance and mental health. If students are present at school, they are more likely to retain the skills they need to improve their academics. School libraires foster an essential connection between school and home. They provide students with both the literary and technological skills they need to be able to connect to real-world events. Libraries create an engaging and motivational environment in which students are excited to learn how to read, engage meaningfully with their peers, and learn greater competency with computers. It is essential for the future of school libraries that they receive the funding they need to be able to provide students with high quality reading materials and technology.

Public schools are tasked with addressing the ongoing crisis in literacy development and are often blamed for their failure to improve academic performance. However, many schools lack the funding, staffing, and instruction necessary to provide reading support individualized for at-risk or below grade-level students. As a result, students who are struggling with literacy go

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[5] Baksh, Salma. "School Libraries Are Essential 'third Spaces' for Students like Me." *Chalkbeat*, Chalkbeat, 4 Apr. 2025, www.chalkbeat.org/newyork/2025/04/04/school-libraries-librarians-unfunded-mandate-in-new-york/.

undetected and without intervention, becoming functionally illiterate. Research shows that literacy established in elementary schools is a significantly more favorable than intervening in later years. Without the early support of reading programs, functional illiteracy becomes ingrained within students, following them throughout their academic careers and into adulthood.

2. Statement of Request

Intervention is urgently needed in the ongoing literacy crisis. I, on behalf of the Children's Literacy Project, respectfully requests funding in the amount of $20,000 dollars to support the implementation of an after-school literacy support program and library enrichment program designed to assist elementary school students who are currently reading below grade level. The proposed program will operate as a two-year pilot program and seeks the amount of $10,000 dollars per year to address harmful and persistent literacy gaps through targeted instructional support and sustained access to high-quality reading resources.

Grant funds will be used to support multiple, interconnected components of the program. A portion of the funding will provide structured after-school literacy instruction, including small-group or individualized reading and writing support focused on foundational skills such as phonics, reading comprehension, sentence structure, and vocabulary development. These sessions will be led by trained instructors and designed to complement classroom learning. By extending learning opportunities beyond the school day, this program aims to provide students with the additional time and support necessary to close literacy gaps before it becomes detrimental.

In addition to after-school support, requested funds will be allocated toward an enrichment of selected school libraries. This includes the acquisition of new, high-quality

reading materials that reflect a range of reading levels, interests, and student backgrounds. Librarians will play a central role in selecting materials that align with the curriculum of the school as well as foster an interest in independent reading. Funding will also support updates to library furnishings, including tables, seating, and reading areas, in order to create a welcoming and inclusive environment that encourages student engagement.

The proposed budget includes investments in education technology to enhance both reading and writing development. Grant funds will support the purchase of computers and tablets, as well as literacy-focused software, to strengthen students' digital literacy and written communication skills. These resources will be integrated into both after-school programs and standard library use, ensuring that all students the technological competencies necessary for academic success in a digital learning landscape.

Funding is requested for a two-year period to allow sufficient time for program implementation, evaluation, and refinement. A pilot phase will enable the organization to assess the short-term academic outcomes of the program, such as improved reading levels and standardized assessment performance, as well as asses the translation of skills learned as students rise in grade level and utilize enhanced library features. Data collected during this period will inform future program expansion and potential implementation into additional schools.

Through this investment, the McCarthey Dressman Education Foundation will play a critical role in addressing early literacy gaps, strengthening the infrastructure of early childhood education, empowering students with the skills necessary to succeed academically and professionally. The requested funding represents a strategic commitment to the power of

literacy by ensuring all students have access to the resources and support needed to become confident, capable readers.

3. Project Description

A. Program Goals and Objectives

Short-term, this project will be measured through academic performance and state examinations. In New York State, students are given the option to take the New York State ELA and Mathematics tests. We will be measuring the success of the program through students who take this exam and comparing their scores on the ELA test to the year prior. We are also hoping to achieve long-term academic confidence in elementary school students, as well as increased access to reading materials. If students are given the support they need in the after-school program, the enriched library experience will work to maintain the foundation built in literacy. Students will also be measured using reading assessments from teachers during class time. In the beginning of the school year, a baseline reading level will be established using a class-time reading assessment. The state tests will serve as a mid-year check. An end-of-year review will analyze student performance and ensure student growth has been achieved.

If the program expands beyond these 2 trial years, I want to expand research into middle school children to see if the work done in elementary schools translates to long-term academic performance. We hope to disrupt the cycle of illiteracy by turning children into confident readers. Many children from low-income homes are not given the same opportunities to improve their literacy levels at home. The after-school program is designed

to combat this issue by providing a safe-space for at-risk children to learn and improve, without judgement from peers. By providing a supportive and judgment-free learning environment, the program addresses educational inequities faced by students from low-income households who may lack literacy resources at home. Literacy is imperative for children and adults to connect meaningfully with the world around them. Improved literacy skills are preparing students for higher education and high-paying careers, preventing the cycle of poverty from continuing.

The enriched library project will be measured through book circulation, student book checkouts, and reading and writing time. A baseline will be determined using previous years book circulation numbers and a week of monitoring how students utilize independent reading time. Library usage in general will also be monitored. Feedback from students will be heavily considered in order to create an environment designed by students, for students.

Together, the measurement of both the library initiative and the after-school program will provide a comprehensive evaluation of the program's effectiveness in improving literacy, academic confidence, and leveling educational equity.

B. After-School Program

The after-school program will take place in the school library. It will be structured around the following principles:

- Improving Reading Skills
- Improving Reading Comprehension
- Improving Writing Skills

Students will be separated into groups of 1-5 students to 1 instructor. Smaller groups will allow for a more accepting and supportive environment as opposed to a traditional classroom. Groups will also be separated by grade level. Each group will be given a passage of fiction or non-fiction to use.

Sessions should be structed into 20-minute increments for a total of one hour. 20 minutes will be devoted to reading aloud with an instructor. Any words that cause confusion will be addressed and grammar rules will be shown through examples. Reading aloud will help students to gain familiarity with unknown words. Some students may be hesitant to read aloud but should be given the opportunity in an environment where they are supported instead of a regular classroom in front of their peers. Students above grade 3 will be encouraged to sound out unfamiliar words and use context clues to decode meaning.

Figure 1: Children Practicing Writing

The second 20-minute segment will be devoted to reading comprehension. Students K-2 will have to identify main characters, the setting, and identify key points. They also will be connecting pictures to text and building sight vocabulary. Students in grades 3 and above will have to provide further discussion on inferences about the reading, understanding themes, and summarize key points.

The final 20-minutes will be devoted to writing. Grades K-2 will only be expected to write basic sentences regarding the source material. They should be supported in terms of spelling and given exercises in handwriting. Higher grades should be expected to write more

intimately about the text. They will also be given basic questions to answer in simple sentences.

These sessions will take place twice times a week on Tuesdays and Thursdays after school from 3:15-4:15 pm. Students will be selected for this program by their teachers through academic performance. During traditional class times, teachers should be encouraged to monitor students who struggle to read aloud, write letters, or remember what they have read. After three weeks of attending the after-school program, students will be evaluated in class. If their reading and/or writing abilities have improved and are on par with grade level, the student will no longer be expected to attend the after-school program.

C. Innovation

The proposed after-school program is innovative in its staffing model, which integrates strong community engagement with educational support. Building a strong sense of community is imperative to child development. It provides them with a sense of belonging and support, fostering emotional growth and self-esteem. Children who feel supported by both peers and educators are more likely to continue to engage with learning. To support this endeavor, the after-school program will work alternately as an internship program for local college students or high school seniors with an interest in early childhood education. By incorporating aspiring educators into the program, this initiative creates a learning environment mutually beneficial for both students and mentors.

College students applying to this program will be required to submit an application one year in advance and must have fulfilled their college-level English language requirement prior to the beginning of the program. High school seniors must also apply the year prior and must provide a recommendation from an English teacher. English teachers will be

encouraged to identify and recommend students with a strong command of language, a love of reading, and a genuine interest in teaching children.

Prior to the program, interns will receive one week of training and guidance from hired teachers and librarians of the school to ensure students are receiving quality mentorship. Interns will participate in training sessions focused on literacy instruction strategies, group management, and professional expectations. Sessions will take place every day from 9:00 AM – 1:00 PM. This training ensures interns are prepared to support their students effectively while also gaining insight into the responsibilities of teaching.

This staffing model will benefit elementary students academically and socially by providing them consistent mentorship from knowledgeable instructors. Younger students often respond positively to near-peer mentors. They look up to mentors as approachable role models, reinforcing the idea that academic success is attainable. At the same time, the program offers meaningful professional development for participating interns. Internship experience is invaluable in helping students explore potential career paths and teaches professional skills in communication, problem-solving, and leadership. Interns will gain hand-on experience in in designing instructional activities, childcare, and classroom management.

By pairing literacy support with community enhancing mentorship, this program strengthens education outcome while cultivating an environment in which students and mentors alike feel supported and enriched.

D. School Library Enrichment

The library enrichment aspect of this project is a roadmap for evolving library services. The main goals of this project are to improve reading materials and give students access to high-quality educational technology. The library enrichment project is designed to modernize physical spaces and directly support literacy development by increasing student exposer to appropriate, engaging, and educational texts that reinforce classroom instruction and independent reading habits.

The enriched library space will be integrated into both the after-school program and the regular school day. Students who participate in the after-school literacy program will use the library for instructional reading support and collaborative activities, while all students will benefit from improved utilities during school hours.

Figure 2: An Elementary School Library

New books will be bought using funds from this grant. School librarians will be given full permission to evaluate reading materials based on curriculum relevance, quality, subject matters, and resource goals. The selection will include a range of reading levels to support emerging, developing, and advanced readers. Multilingual and culturally representative texts will also be included to reflect the identities and experiences of the student population. An assortment of books ranging from educational, recreational, and informational should be selected for students. A multitude of genres will be included in the updated books. Non-fiction and educational books are important for academic purposes, but fiction novels such as fantasy, historical fiction, and realistic fiction are

invaluable to introducing children to reading. Students who read purely for enjoyment are more likely to continue to do so. Forcing students to read books that are not enjoyable for them will not further our mission of creating confident readers. During library time, students will be encouraged to read books that they pick out themselves to promote creativity and individuality. Updated technology including desktop computers and tablets will be used to inspire creativity and improve literacy alongside computer literacy. Students in grades K-5 will be given access to a computer library that are used for educational and creative purposes. Technology usage will be supervised by teachers and instructors, and all content will be age-appropriate with filters in place to ensure student safety.

By transforming the school library into a welcoming, resource-rich learning environment, the project reinforces the idea that literacy is both and academic skill and source of empowerment. A well-designed library spaces fosters creativity and a sense of belonging, motivating students to engage with reading and learning long after leaving the educational space.

Phase	Proposed Start Date	Proposed End Date	Total Proposed Timeframe
Establish Baseline	December 1, 2026	December 12, 2026	12 Days of Literacy Assessment
Mid-Year Check In	April 13, 2027	April 17, 2027	3 Days of State Assessment, 2 Days of In-Class Assessment
End-of-Year Assessment	June 1, 2027	June 12, 2027	12 Days of Literacy Assessment

Figure 2: Proposed Schedule

4. Description of Available Facilities

This program will be held at the Lafrancis Hardiman Elementary School, located in Wyandanch, New York. Wyandanch School District has faced persistent socio-economic challenges and has been historically underfunded. This school supports approximately 445 students from kindergarten through 5th grade. A vast majority of the student population is Hispanic or Latino, followed by Black or African American, populations that have historically been underserved in terms of access to educational resources and support programs.[6]

The school library provides an ideal setting for the proposal's implementation. The space is large enough to comfortably hold two full classes of students and is well-suited for small-group instructions during after-school sessions. The library is equipped with tables that allow for collaborative learning and desktop computers available for educational software and writing exercises. A rug and relaxed seating arrangement provides a comfortable and enticing environment for independent reading. The school library will act as a central hub for the after-school program and for elementary literacy through the library enhancement project.

Figure 3: Students at Lafrancis Hardiman Elementary School

[6] https://data.nysed.gov/enrollment.php?year=2025&instid=800000037746

5. Qualification of Personnel

The Children's Literacy Project (CLP) has been mobilizing literacy initiatives into elementary schools, churches, and community groups for 10 years. They partner with and build up local organizations to foster community growth from the ground up. The Children's Literacy Project believes in transforming lives and communities through the power of literacy and are working towards a world in which all children are reading proficiently by the 4th grade.

Our co-founder and creative director of the CLP is Tony Kriz. He is an award-winning writer, a professor, an author, and international speaker. Mr. Kriz symbolizes the heart of our mission, travelling the world and provoking audiences toward goodness and truth through literacy.

Our executive director, Steve Sammons, boasts 25 years of experience in organizational growth and transformations. He excels in harnessing data-driven strategies, leading teams, and forging partnerships to meet and surpass objectives. Mr. Sammons would be an invaluable asset to this proposal as we navigate the pilot phase of the project.

Our final key member of staff is Susan Coleman, executive assistant to Steve Sammons. She is a skilled communicator with a Master of Arts in Intercultural Studies. She is the mayor of Sweet Home, Oregon, with years of experience in literacy and education. Mrs. Coleman empowers collaboration between groups to bring about meaningful change and would be capable of spearheading this proposal and overseeing its execution.

6. Budget

This project requests a grant for $20,000 over a 2-year period. This amount will be split into one $10,000 fund per year. Interns will serve on a volunteer basis, freeing up grant funds to compensate certified teachers who will lead a one-week summer training program to prepare interns in effective literary instruction. Additional funding supports instructional materials, library enrichment, educational technology, and evaluation in the 2nd year period.

Year 1: $10,000

Use of Funds	Expense Report	Expense Time Frame	Amount
Teacher Training Stipend	Compensation for certified teachers to design and lead a one-week summer training for interns.	Summer	$2,025 3 teachers, $45/hour for 15 hours.
Literacy Instruction Materials	Workbooks, writing exercises, handwriting guides, and other resources used during after-school support.	Beginning of program and as needed.	$2,000
School Library Books	High-quality fiction and nonfiction texts across grade levels.	Beginning of program.	$2,000
Educational Technology	Tablets, desktop computers, and literacy software subscriptions to support instruction.	Beginning of program and as necessary.	$2,025

Library Furniture Upgrades	Durable tables, chairs, and reading-area seating to create an environment conducive to learning.	Beginning of program.	$1,450
Program Supplies & Printing	Student journals, folders, assessment tools, and printing costs.	Throughout program.	$500

Figure 4: Year 1 Budget

Year 2: $10,000

Use of Funds	Expense Report	Expense Time Frame	Amount
Continued Teacher Training Stipend	Compensation for certified teachers to design and lead a one-week summer training for interns, expanded on from year 1.	Summer	$2,025 3 teachers, $45/hour for 15 hours.
Advanced Literacy Instruction Materials	Additional workbooks, writing exercises, handwriting guides, and other resources based on student progress and program evaluation.	Beginning of program and as needed.	$1,000
School Library Books	High-quality fiction and nonfiction texts across grade levels.	Beginning of program.	$2,500
Educational Technology	Software renewals and device maintenance/replacement as needed.	Beginning of program and as necessary.	$2,475
Evaluation & Assessment tools	Reading diagnostics, surveys, data tracking materials, and internal investigation into the effectiveness of the program.	Throughout the program.	$1,500
Program Supplies & Printing	Student journals, folders, assessment tools, and printing costs.	Throughout program.	$500

Figure 5: Year 2 Budget

7. Summary

This after-school literacy and library enrichment program is a targeted response to the growing literacy crisis affecting elementary school students, especially in low-income communities. By combining structured after-school literacy support with investment in school library resources, this project addresses both the academic and environmental factors that contribute to literacy development. Students who struggle with reading are often left to develop independently, allowing functional illiteracy to fester and deplete academic confidence. This program seeks to intervene in early childhood and offer supportive instruction in a safe and welcoming environment.

The design of the project prioritizes quality and community engagement. Interns from local high schools and colleges will be selected and trained by district teachers through a structured summer program, ensuring that instruction is effective and created by trained professionals. This model supports elementary students as well as create a generation of aspiring educators who are invested in the academic success of their community. This proposed project centers the school library as a hub of enrichment and instruction for students and mentors alike.

Through measurable outcomes such as reading assessment goals, reading level surveys, and academic success, this program is positioned to make a meaningful and lasting impact. With a grant funding of $20,000 over two years, this project is financially responsible and scalable. Ultimately, this initiative seeks not only to improve literacy rates but also to empower children with the skills and confidence they need to succeed academically and professionally in the world around them.

Appendix

Cover Photo:

Storytime at Nursery. *IStock*, https://www.istockphoto.com/photo/storytime-at-nursery-gm544351338-97825007.

Figure 1:

School Girl Writing. *IStock*, https://www.istockphoto.com/photo/school-girl-writing-in-class-gm950614324-259474522.

Figure 2:

Elementary School Library. *Education Week*, https://www.edweek.org/teaching-learning/how-this-school-librarian-transformed-the-library-and-got-more-kids-to-read/2025/06.

Figure 3:

First Graders Celebrating World Kindness Day. *The Beacon*, https://www.babylonbeacon.com/articles/lafrancis-hardiman-elementary-celebrates-world-kindness-day/.

Figure 4:

Table of Year 1 Budget

Figure 5:

Table of Year 2 Budget

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